

SPARTAN COACHING

DISCIPLINE | EMPATHY | STRATEGY

PRE-CALL RESEARCH CHECKLIST

Complete Preparation for Every Referral Source Visit

A 40-item research protocol covering facility intelligence, contact preparation, competitive positioning, and clinical context for each call.

Pre-Call Research Checklist

Preparation Separates Spartan Reps from the Competition

WHY RESEARCH MATTERS

Most hospice reps walk into facilities knowing only the name on the door. Spartan-trained reps know the census numbers, the decision-makers, the clinical challenges, the competitive situation, and what that specific contact cares about most. The rep who is most prepared wins the conversation before it starts.

Use this checklist before every new account introduction and before any major meeting at an existing account. Abbreviated research takes 15 minutes. Full research for a high-value new account should take 45 to 60 minutes. Never skip it.

FACILITY-LEVEL RESEARCH (ALL ACCOUNT TYPES)

Organizational Basics

- ☐ Facility name, address, ownership group, and number of locations in the system
- ☐ Type of facility and licensed bed count or panel size
- ☐ Ownership structure: for-profit, nonprofit, faith-based, or government
- ☐ Part of a larger health system or independent operation
- ☐ Any recent news about the facility (expansions, closings, leadership changes, awards)
- ☐ Current census utilization rate if available publicly

CMS Data and Quality Metrics

- ☐ CMS Five Star Quality Rating for SNFs (cms.gov/care-compare)
- ☐ Most recent standard survey results and any deficiencies noted
- ☐ Quality measure scores compared to state and national averages
- ☐ Staffing hours per resident per day (a key quality indicator)
- ☐ For hospitals: readmission rates, HCAHPS scores, value-based purchasing results
- ☐ For home health: OASIS outcomes and agency compare star ratings

Current Hospice Activity

- ☐ Which hospice providers are currently active in this facility or with this physician
- ☐ Estimated volume: how many referrals per month, if knowable
- ☐ Any known dissatisfaction with current hospice partner
- ☐ Whether any patients have been on long hospice stays or had recertifications

- ☐ Whether the facility has its own palliative care program

CONTACT-LEVEL RESEARCH

LinkedIn and Professional Profiles

- ☐ Years in current role and years at this facility
- ☐ Prior work history: what settings have they worked in?
- ☐ Educational background and professional credentials
- ☐ Any publications, presentations, or professional affiliations
- ☐ Shared connections with your network or colleagues in common
- ☐ Recent posts or comments that reveal priorities and interests
- ☐ Volunteer work, community involvement, or causes they support

Role and Decision Authority

- ☐ Exact role in the referral decision process (recommender, approver, influencer)
- ☐ Who they report to and who they collaborate with on care decisions
- ☐ How long they have been in the decision-making role
- ☐ Whether they have a preferred hospice provider and how loyal they are to it

FACILITY-SPECIFIC RESEARCH BY TYPE

Skilled Nursing Facilities

- ☐ Specialty units: dementia care, wound care, short-term rehab, ventilator
- ☐ Average resident acuity and primary diagnoses
- ☐ Recent survey findings related to end-of-life care practices
- ☐ Staffing model: what is the typical CNA-to-resident and RN-to-resident ratio?

Hospitals

- ☐ Key service lines: oncology, cardiology, neurology, pulmonary
- ☐ Current readmission rates for CHF, pneumonia, COPD
- ☐ Whether they have a palliative care team and what its scope is
- ☐ Average length of stay for patients who die in-hospital

Physician Offices

- ☐ Specialty: primary care, oncology, cardiology, neurology, geriatrics
- ☐ Patient panel size and estimated number with serious illness
- ☐ Whether they have participated in MACRA / MIPS quality reporting
- ☐ Any known interest in advance care planning or goals of care conversations

COMPETITIVE INTELLIGENCE

- ☐ Primary hospice competitors in the territory: list names and market position
- ☐ Which competitor currently holds this account and how long
- ☐ Known strengths and weaknesses of each competitor
- ☐ Any recent changes at the competitor: staffing, ownership, reputation
- ☐ Whether the account has ever changed hospice providers and why
- ☐ Whether there is a formal or informal preferred vendor agreement in place

CALL PREPARATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Identify one specific question about their patient population to open with
- ☐ Select one educational resource relevant to their primary diagnosis mix
- ☐ Prepare one relevant outcome or data point, not a product spec
- ☐ Have a clear ask for the end of the conversation (meeting, lunch-and-learn, follow-up call)
- ☐ Know who else in the building you want to meet during the same visit
- ☐ Check your CRM for the last visit notes and any open commitments you made

THE PREPARATION PAYOFF

Research is not busywork. It is competitive advantage. When you can reference specific CMS quality data, mention a shared connection, or ask a question that shows you understand their specific challenges, you immediately separate yourself from every other rep who showed up with brochures and a business card. Preparation communicates respect for their time. Showing up unprepared communicates the opposite.